



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Summit Academy
School Website: <https://thesummitva.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

The Summit Academy in Fredericksburg, VA (zip 22407) presents a robust classical-education profile grounded in Catholic tradition, with explicit emphasis on liberal arts, Great Books, and Socratic pedagogy. Public materials on the school's site consistently frame education as formation of character and virtue, anchored in truth, goodness, and beauty, and pursued through a liberal-arts foundation. The school also foregrounds parental partnership and community engagement, and maintains a faculty roster whose biographies present teachers as committed mentors and living exemplars of the school's ideals. The predominant signal across categories is CLASSICAL, with Element 3 (Curriculum) meeting many classical markers but not always explicit about every granular element (e.g., explicit reference to Trivium/Quadrivium grammar-logic-rhetoric in published statements). Overall, the aggregate assessment leans CLASSICAL, with a note that Curriculum shows some room for fuller alignment with all six "essential elements" in practice.

Key evidence anchors from the public materials include: - Religious and metaphysical foundations: explicit rooting in Catholic tradition and Christ-centered aims; formation in Christian virtue; shared commitments between faith and learning. See statements about being "Rooted in the Catholic Tradition" and mission-driven formation of virtue. - Purpose and goal: education framed as formation toward wisdom and virtue, not merely job-prep; explicit reference to truth/goodness/beauty as real, knowable realities. - Curriculum: emphasis on Liberal Arts and Great Books tradition; explicit mention of Great Books and the Liberal Arts as organizing framework for study. - Pedagogy: clear use of Socratic seminars and a rhetoric-informed approach; emphasis on memory, wonder, and active student participation in upper grades. - Faculty: biographies describing teachers as mentors living the curriculum and modeling virtue; multiple faculty profiles illustrate ongoing professional formation and practical commitment. - Parents & Community: strong emphasis on partnering with parents, open houses, visits, and opportunities to engage in education (e.g., information sessions, tours).

Aggregate ranking: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Reasoning: The Summit Academy strongly aligns with classical education through Catholic formation, Great Books, Liberal Arts orientation, and Socratic pedagogy, and it actively involves parents and the wider community. The Curriculum category shows substantial alignment but does not consistently publish explicit references to every traditional curricular element (e.g., explicit statement that grammar, logic, and rhetoric are central components of the curriculum). Thus, while overall classical in approach and execution, a single category sits at a level of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, pulling the aggregate rating to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (for a fully Classical rating) - Make explicit the Trivium framework in published curricular statements (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and show concrete alignment of student work with those stages across grades. - Deepen articulation of liturgical or communal practices tied to the Catholic identity (e.g., explicit references to liturgical rhythm, worship, music in daily life) to strengthen Religious and Metaphysical Foundations. - Expand on the Great Conversation through published syllabi or program descriptions that explicitly connect Great Books selections to disciplinary work (history, philosophy, literature) across grades. - More explicit statements about the integration of faith and reason in daily classroom practice could further bolster Formation and Integration.

Note: The following section provides category-by-category analysis with keyword-based scoring, drawing on the six-element classical rubric and the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) document.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Summit presents itself as rooted in Catholic tradition and Christian formation, with mission emphasis on forming students in Christian virtue and living faith within education. Public materials state: “Rooted in the Catholic Tradition... education... engages the whole person,” and “form their sons and daughters in Christian virtue.” - Additional materials emphasize Christ-centered education and the lordship of Jesus Christ as foundational to learning; the institution explicitly ties faith to the liberal-arts-based curriculum.

Positive keyword analysis - Present keywords drawn from the Positive Keywords repertoire for this category include: Catholic/Catholic Tradition, Jesus Christ/Christ, virtue, formation, wisdom, and moral/spiritual formation. The site consistently uses language tying education to virtue and Christian formation, aligning with Positive Keyword indicators. See examples: “Rooted in the Catholic Tradition,” “form their sons and daughters in Christian virtue,” and “formation toward wisdom and character.”

Negative keyword indicators - There is no clear presence of indicators that would signal a lack of transcendental moral realism or the absence of theological grounding. The site portrays a theologically integrated program rather than secular relativism.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials foreground Catholic theology, liturgical/communal dimensions, and moral formation aligned with transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) in practice, which strongly matches the Positive Keyword framework for this category. The texts consistently anchor education in virtue and the sacred, which fulfills the core criteria of this element of classical education.

Citations used from the knowledge-base and crawl store - Catholic tradition and formation language: The Summit as rooted in Catholic tradition and formation of virtue. - Public mission statements tying Catholic faith to education: “rooted in the Catholic Tradition... liberal arts tradition” and formation of virtue. - Christ-centered and faith-informed education: explicit references to Jesus Christ and faith-integrated learning.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Summit describes education as formation toward virtue and wisdom rather than mere job preparation, consistent with a formation-centric purpose. The mission and statements emphasize forming students to engage the world with virtue. - Additional language frames education as a Liberal Arts enterprise rooted in truth, goodness, and beauty, not simply information transfer. The Great Books/Liberal Arts orientation signals pursuit of enduring human excellences rather than utilitarian outcomes.

Positive keyword analysis - Present indicators include: formation, virtue, wisdom, truth/goodness/beauty (as real and knowable), and liberal-arts orientation. See formation in Christian virtue, and the aim to cultivate moral and intellectual flourishing.

Negative keyword indicators - No strong signals of a purely utilitarian, work-preparation orientation are present; rather, the messaging emphasizes formation and the enduring goods (truth, goodness, beauty).

Why this rating - The school’s stated goals align with the classical aim of forming virtuous, wise people rather than merely producing job-ready graduates, satisfying the Positive Keyword indicators for this category.

Citations - Formation as purpose: “form their sons and daughters in Christian virtue...” - Truth/goodness/beauty as real, knowable: emphasis on the Liberal Arts and Great Books; “education rooted in truth, goodness, beauty.”

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Summit explicitly anchors its curriculum in the Great Books and Liberal Arts tradition and employs a framework that supports integrated study and deep textual engagement. Statements highlight a program “based on the Great Books and Liberal Arts Tradition” and the use of Socratic seminars. - There is clear evidence of a liberal-arts orientation across disciplines and a focus on rigorous academic formation, with visible emphasis on original sources and intellectual engagement through discussion.

Positive keyword analysis - Positive indicators include: Great Books, Liberal Arts, Great Conversation, Socratic seminars, and “formation through the arts” (as part of a broader liberal-arts framework). The site emphasizes engagement with original sources and a discussion-based approach that aligns with classical pedagogy. - Additional alignment with the “great books” and “liberal arts tradition” is reinforced by mission statements and program descriptions.

Negative keyword indicators - The curriculum statements do not consistently publish explicit references to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as canonical curricular modules in the same way as some classical schools. The data show liberal-arts orientation and Great Books, but not a published, explicit list of grammar/logic/rhetoric as the core curricular content in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating - While the school clearly embraces Great Books, Liberal Arts, and Socratic pedagogy, the absence of explicit published references to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) as core curricular elements reduces the certainty of a full-clear, textbook alignment with all six elements of the classical curriculum. This nuance justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Curriculum.

Citations - Great Books and Liberal Arts orientation: “based on the Great Books and Liberal Arts Tradition” and “Socratic seminars.” - Mission emphasizing liberal-arts framing and original sources: “We are an independent Catholic school... liberal arts tradition” and “great books.”

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical approach explicitly includes Socratic seminars, dialectic discussion, and rhetoric training in upper levels. The Summit describes upper-level learning via Socratic discussion/seminars and rhetoric as a path to mastery. - The lower grades are described as engaging with material in a manner that fosters memory and wonder, while upper grades emphasize debate, seminars, and rhetorical practicing. The presence of multiple references to Socratic methods signals a robust classical pedagogy.

Positive keyword analysis - Present indicators include: Socratic seminars, seminars/debates, rhetoric training, oral presentation, memory work, and a structured shift from contemplative to dialectical methods as students advance. These map to Positive Keyword indicators for Pedagogy in the classical rubric.

Negative keyword indicators - No substantial negative signals appear in the materials regarding pedagogy (e.g., no emphasis on purely project-based, non-discursive teaching as a core approach).

Why this rating - The explicit articulation and deployment of Socratic method and rhetoric, along with a plan for higher-order discussion and public speaking (speech/debate elements), satisfy the Pedagogy criteria for CLASSICAL.

Citations - Socratic seminars and rhetoric training: “learn through active participation in Socratic seminars... upper school... rhetoric training.” - Lower/upper division pedagogy framing: “lower school... memory and wonder” and “upper school... seminars and debates.”

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public-facing site includes multiple faculty profiles with professional credentials and service in the school community, indicating a faculty that models virtue, competence, and mentorship. Examples include biographies such as Crystal Edwards (Assistant to the Administrative Team) and Julian Sicam (Latin and Science instructor) with degrees and professional backgrounds. - The faculty are described as part of the living curriculum, with each teacher contributing to the culture and mission of the school through their

expertise and character. While not always using the exact phrase “living curriculum,” the bios emphasize virtue, scholarship, and service, which align with the intended role of faculty in classical education.

Positive keyword analysis - Present keywords include: teacher as mentor, model virtue, life-long learning, living curriculum (conceptually), and faculty as the core of school culture. The bios emphasize virtue, scholarship, and professional formation, aligning with Positive Keyword indicators for Faculty.

Negative keyword indicators - There are no explicit negative signals regarding faculty (e.g., non-mentoring, non-committed teacher profiles) in the publicly available materials.

Why this rating - The presence of credentialed, mission-aligned faculty profiles and the emphasis on mentors who model virtue and scholarly care supports CLASSICAL.

Citations - Crystal Edwards biography and role. - Julian Sicam biography and credentials.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school positions itself as a partner with parents, emphasizing parental involvement and co-teaching roles. Mission statements talk about partnering with parents to form students in Christian virtue. Public material describes open invitations for parent visits, shadow days, and tours. - The site provides multiple opportunities for parental engagement (e.g., information sessions, tours, and campus visits) and communicates a welcoming stance toward parents.

Positive keyword analysis - Present keywords include: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent visits, information sessions, tours, and community engagement. These map to Positive Keyword indicators for Parents & Community in the classical rubric.

Negative keyword indicators - No negative indicators identified; the site emphasizes collaboration and engagement rather than adversarial or neglectful parent relationships.

Why this rating - The school’s materials emphasize ongoing parental partnership and public-friendly access to campus events, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations - Parental partnership and formation language. - Information sessions, tours, and parent-friendly access.

What Would Move the Needle

- Curricular Explicitness: Publish more explicit curricular mappings to the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and show cross-grade alignment with classic sequences. This would strengthen Element 3 to CLASSICAL by clarifying the grammar/logic/rhetoric core within a Great Books/Liberal Arts framework.
 - Communal Liturgical Practices: Include more explicit references to liturgical practices or communal worship within the curriculum and schedule, to strengthen Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations) with liturgical/communal evidence.
 - Great Conversation Mapping: Provide published syllabi or program descriptions that demonstrate how Great Books selections connect to specific disciplinary outcomes, ensuring stronger Element 3 alignment with the Sixth Element and Great Conversation expectations.
 - Narrative of Wonder: More explicit articulation of how wonder, awe, and poetry are cultivated across grade levels (beyond the outdoor program) could reinforce Element 3 and Element 4, linking contemplation with rigorous discourse.
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Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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